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Blog

White House Announces Plan to Provide Solar Energy for Renters

CHAZ WILKE ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/AUTHOR/CHAZW/](https://solarmehome.com/author/chaZW/)) / JULY 9, 2015 ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/WHITE-HOUSE-ANNOUNCES-PLAN-TO-PROVIDE-SOLAR-ENERGY-FOR-RENTERS/](https://solarmehome.com/white-house-announces-plan-to-provide-solar-energy-for-renters/))



The Obama administration says that the average American renter has limited access to clean energy. Without a garage to charge a Tesla and without owning the roof to add solar panels, renters have been stuck in the fossil fuel stone age, until now.

A new plan revealed on July 7 by the White House hopes to address this issue. “The program includes a commitment to install 300 megawatts of new solar panels on federally subsidized housing by 2020,” reports Robert Ferris of CNBC. The program is also planning to “offer loans and ‘toolkits’ that will make it easier for low-income Americans to draw their energy from solar power and improve energy efficiency in their homes.”

It’s unknown how much, if anything, this will cost the consumer.

This community solar announcement comes not long after the White House announced a joint agreement with Brazil that promises the United States will get 20 percent of the nation’s total electricity from clean energy by 2030.

Achieving 20 percent renewable energy by 2030 is welcome news, but not as bold as a recent study suggested. Mark Z. Jacobson of Stanford's Atmosphere and Energy Program revealed that we could operate at 80 percent (<http://bit.ly/1IMwK7o>) renewable energy by that same year. But that projection neglects to take into account the reality of America's polarized political climate.

What 300 megawatts gets you

When hard numbers are thrown around, many readers may have trouble understanding just how much power 300 MW actually is in everyday energy use. In short, 300 MW is a good start. For a program looking to help the less fortunate, many thousands of households may find relief under this new plan.

The Solar Energy Industries Association estimates (<http://bit.ly/1To9O1B>) the national average of homes that a single MW can power stands at roughly 164 homes. The average takes into consideration the range of variance of optimal direct sunlight hitting the panels. So using that average as a baseline, the White House's new plan intends to power roughly 49,200 homes annually.

Other programs in the works

This program targeting relief for low-income residents is only one of many in the works. The White House revealed that local government, NGOs (Non-Governmental Organizations) and other private companies have committed roughly \$520 million toward increased solar energy use and additional programs encompassing a total of 260 projects spanning 20 states.

This should come as welcome news for those who don't own a home. Renters and low-income households have been all but excluded from the clean energy revolution underway across the globe. This new program as well as the others mentioned above will likely help spread the solar panel benefit across all demographics and income brackets.

This means new jobs, too

Along with the good news for renters, these programs are projected to add jobs to the economy as well. "The president wants to create 75,000 solar industry jobs by 2020 as well, and plans to use AmeriCorps funding to train workers for solar jobs, according to the White house announcement," reports (<http://nbcnews.to/1KXU7eB>) Ferris.

The White House revealed that in the past year the solar industry added jobs at a rate ten times faster than all other industries. Solar's cost continues to decrease as well, in fact the cost of solar electricity is half what it cost in 2010, according to Brian Deese, the president's senior climate change advisor. This means solar installation and maintenance jobs are more in demand than ever.

Takeaway

The push toward renewable energy has, up to this point, been a relatively private enterprise endeavor. Most attention and effort had previously been on private homeowners gaining energy independence. Now, with the new White House plan, renters and low-income residents may soon gain the benefit of enjoying clean, renewable energy like those lucky homeowners that have already installed rooftop solar panels.

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